

100

Screen-Free Plays for Ages 0–5

Easy, low-prep play and talk ideas for babies, toddlers and preschoolers, sorted by age

0–1

1–2

2–3

3–5

Prep budget: no prep for 66 plays, about 2 minutes for 31 and about 10 minutes for 3. 89 plays need nothing to buy.



Play Before Pixels

100 Screen-Free Plays for Ages 0–5

Easy, low-prep play and talk ideas for babies, toddlers and preschoolers, sorted by age

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Please read. This book offers play ideas and general parent education. It is not medical, developmental or professional advice, and it does not diagnose, treat or prevent any condition. Every play is meant to be done with a grown-up right there. Ages are a guide: you know your child best, so skip or change any play that does not feel right. Always follow the safety notes and the "Safety first" page.

No brands, apps, devices, products, schools or programs are named, reviewed or endorsed in this book. Any object shown is generic.

Research sources are listed on the "Sources" page.

Every play follows our published safety rules (the "Safety first" page). Print what you need for use in your own home.

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A note before you start

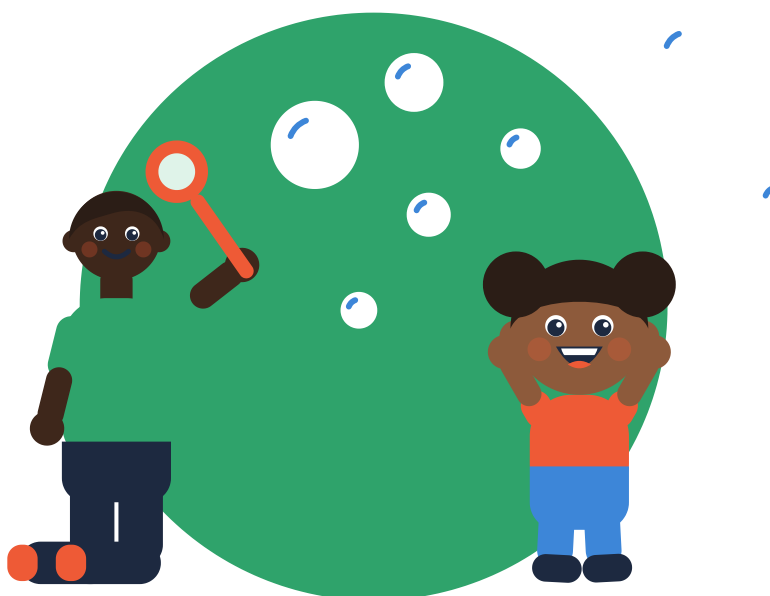
This book is for ordinary days: rainy mornings, long afternoons and the ten minutes before dinner. You don't need special toys, a craft cupboard or a perfect plan. Most of these plays use a cup, a box, a sock or nothing at all.

You don't need to do all 100, either. Pick one that fits your child's age and your energy today. Try it, talk while you play, and see what your child does with it. Some plays will be a hit and some will flop. Both are fine.

The best part is the back-and-forth. You say something, your child answers with a look, a sound or a word, and you answer back. That's the whole idea.

Have fun, and go easy on yourself.

Play Before Pixels



How to use this book

The 100 plays are sorted into four age bands. Start with your child's band, then look one band either side: children don't read the labels, and a favorite play can last for years.

0–1

Birth to 1 year
Plays 1–20

1–2

1 to 2 years
Plays 21–45

2–3

2 to 3 years
Plays 46–70

3–5

3 to 5 years
Plays 71–100

Every play has the same parts

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>21 Number and starting age
"From 12 mo" is the youngest age the play suits. "Best for" gives the usual range. You know your child best.</p> <hr/> <p> Mess level
No drops: no mess. One drop: a little mess. Two drops: messy (lay down a towel).</p> <hr/> <p> Where
Indoors, outdoors, bath time, kitchen, waiting and car, wind-down or big energy.</p> <hr/> <p> Make it easier, make it harder
One way to make the play simpler today and one way to stretch it next time.</p> <hr/> <p> Safety note
Read it every time. The full rules are on the "Safety first" page.</p> | <p> Prep time
No prep, about 2 minutes, or about 10 minutes of setting up.</p> <hr/> <p> Play time
About 5, about 10, or 20 minutes or more. Many children play longer or shorter, and both are fine.</p> <hr/> <p> You need
Everyday things. 89 plays carry the Nothing to buy badge; the pantry list shows what to gather.</p> <hr/> <p> Talk while you play
A line to say, tagged with one of six easy talk moves (next page).</p> <hr/> <p>2 Too tired today?
Turn to Tired-grown-up plays: 2 minutes, no setup, played from the couch or the floor.</p> |
|---|--|

3 **Three plays a day is a great day.** One in the morning, one outside and one to wind down. Most children love 2 or 3 of these plays and ask for them again and again; that's normal. If interest fades, stop, and try another day.

Every child is different. If a texture, sound or touch bothers your child, change the play or skip it: a spoon instead of hands, watching first or sitting beside you all count. Big brothers and sisters can lead plays too, with a grown-up right there.

Six easy moves

Every play has a talk line tagged with one of these moves. They are plain, everyday ways to take turns talking. There is nothing to memorize: pick one and try it today.

1 Pause and wait

Say a little, then stop. Count to five in your head and give your child room to answer with a look, a sound, a word or a gesture.

“Ready, set... (wait) ...go!”

2 Say what you see

Put words to what your child is looking at or doing, right as it happens. No questions needed.

“You’re stirring. Stir, stir, stir.”

3 Repeat and add one

When your child says or shows something, say it back and add one more word: “Ball.” “Big ball!”

Child: “Ball.” You: “Big ball!”

4 Offer a choice

Hold up two options and wait. Pointing, reaching and looking all count as answers.

“Bubbles or blocks?”

5 Follow their lead

Let your child choose what to do and how. Join in, copy them and talk about their idea.

“Oh, Teddy goes in the box! In he goes.”

6 Sing and gesture

Songs, rhythm and simple hand moves make words easy to join in with. Repeat the same ones often.

“Wave bye-bye... bye-bye, bath!”

Any answer counts: a look, a smile, a point, a sound, a sign, a tap on a talking device or a word. If your child doesn't answer, that's fine too. Say the word yourself, smile and keep playing.

Talk, sing and read in the language you know best. Every language counts.

Say the talk lines in your own words and your own language, and swap any song for one your family knows.

Safety first



The toilet-paper tube test

For children under 3: if something fits through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in or 3.2 cm across), it is too small to play with. Check toys, lids, food and anything a big sibling leaves out.

- ✓ **A grown-up is always right there.** Every play in this book is for doing together, not for leaving a child alone with.
- ✓ **No balloons for children under 8.** Uninflated or popped balloons are a choking risk.
- ✓ **No cords or strings long enough to wrap around a neck.** That includes blind and curtain cords, ribbons, costume ties and charger cables.
- ✓ **Water: stay within arm's reach.** Even shallow water, even for a moment. Tip out tubs, buckets and bowls as soon as play ends.
- ✓ **Food: soft, small and sitting down.** No whole grapes, nuts, popcorn, raw apple or hard candy for toddlers. Cut food into small, soft pieces, and check for allergies before a new food.
- ✓ **Button batteries and small magnets stay locked away.** Swallowing one is an emergency. Keep battery covers screwed shut.
- ✓ **Outdoors: traffic, sun and water first.** Stay where you can see each other. No berries, mushrooms or small stones in hands or mouths.
- ✓ **Sleep safely.** Tummy time only while your baby is awake and watched. Babies sleep on their backs, in a clear crib.

In an emergency call your local emergency number (911 in the US). If you think your child has swallowed something harmful, call Poison Control (1-800-222-1222 in the US) or your local poison center. Ages in this book are a guide: if a play does not feel safe for your child, skip it or change it.

Why play? Why talk?

You don't need to be a teacher or buy anything special. Everyday play and talk, a few minutes at a time, is something every family can do.

Back-and-forth is the heart of it

Taking turns (you say something, your child answers with a look, a sound or a word, and you answer back) is the simplest thing in this book, and the one we come back to on every page. A 2024 study linked more screen time at age 3 with fewer adult words, fewer child sounds and fewer back-and-forth turns at home each day (Brushe and colleagues, *JAMA Pediatrics*). That is a link, not proof that screens cause it. It is a good reminder that everyday conversation is worth making room for.

Moving counts

The World Health Organization (2019) recommends that children aged 1 to 4 spend at least 180 minutes a day in a variety of physical activities, spread through the day. Babies do well with plenty of floor play, including tummy time while awake. Look for plays marked **Big energy** in the Quick finder.

Screens, gently

The same WHO guidelines say that sedentary screen time is not recommended for babies under 1 or for 1-year-olds, and that for 2- to 4-year-olds it should be no more than 1 hour a day, with less being better. Real life has screens in it. Turn to **When screens are on anyway** (page 81) for friendly, practical ideas.

This book is parent education, not medical advice. If you ever have questions about how your child is growing, moving or talking, ask your child's doctor. In the US, every state runs a free early intervention program for babies and toddlers, and your child's doctor can point you to it.

A play for every moment

Find the moment, then pick a number from your child's band: **1-20** ages 0-1 ·

21-45 ages 1-2 · **46-70** ages 2-3 · **71-100** ages 3-5

Nothing needed

No materials at all · 17 plays

1 3 5 16 18 36 40 44 61 69 70 73 76 80 84 88 95

Big energy

Rainy-day wiggles, indoors and out · 20 plays

5 9 17 20 22 26 29 30 36 39 44 50 52 56 61 76 79 80 94 99

Outdoors

Garden, park, path and puddles · 18 plays

15 25 26 41 49 56 57 69 74 76 79 80 83 88 89 90 93 99

In the kitchen

Play while you cook and tidy · 16 plays

11 20 31 32 37 43 48 49 55 58 65 75 78 81 86 92

Bath time

Always within arm's reach · 5 plays

8 31 40 60 93

Waiting & car

Queues, waiting rooms, passenger seats · 9 plays

16 28 35 45 54 70 73 84 96

Wind-down

Calm plays for before bed · 10 plays

1 19 53 59 66 70 72 77 95 100

10-minute setups

Worth it for a long afternoon · 3 plays

23 46 71

Set up for easy play

A little setup makes play easy to start on a busy day. None of this needs buying: look in your cupboards and recycling first.

A play basket

Keep a basket of everyday play things within easy reach. When you need a play fast, it's already there. See the list for each age below.

Rotate, don't buy

Keep 6 to 8 toys out and put the rest away. Swap a few each week. Old toys feel new again.

A "yes" space

One safe corner where everything in reach is fine to touch, so you can say "yes" more and "no" less.

Bored is OK

Children don't need entertaining every minute. Playing alone nearby while you cook or rest counts as play too.

What to keep in the basket

Ages 0–1

a blanket on the floor
an unbreakable baby mirror
board books
a soft ball
plastic cups and a bowl
a clean dish towel

Ages 1–2

a laundry basket
large cardboard boxes
a big bowl or bucket
painter's tape
plastic tubs with lids
a pot and a wooden spoon

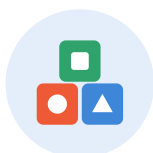
Ages 2–3

chunky crayons and big paper
sidewalk chalk
a pillowcase
toy pots, cups and a teapot
a flashlight
rain boots

Ages 3–5

a big cardboard box
a blanket and chairs
store-bought play dough
paper, tape and crayons
dress-up hats and bags
a notebook for plans

For children under 3, every item must pass the toilet-paper tube test. Check the basket often for broken or small pieces.



The pantry list

89 of the 100 plays carry the  **NOTHING TO BUY** badge. They use only things like these 25, which most homes already have. Gather a few into the play basket and you're ready.

Kitchen

- ☐ plastic cups
- ☐ a big bowl or bucket
- ☐ pots with lids
- ☐ a wooden spoon
- ☐ plastic tubs with lids
- ☐ rolled oats
- ☐ paper plates
- ☐ a clean dish towel

Around the house

- ☐ a blanket
- ☐ pillows and sofa cushions
- ☐ washcloths
- ☐ clean socks
- ☐ a pillowcase
- ☐ a laundry basket
- ☐ a flashlight

Recycling

- ☐ cardboard boxes, big and small
- ☐ an empty tissue box
- ☐ a shoebox
- ☐ big plastic lids
- ☐ paper bags

Paper and toys

- ☐ paper
- ☐ crayons (chunky for under-3s)
- ☐ board books
- ☐ a soft ball bigger than a fist
- ☐ a teddy or doll

For children under 3: everything must pass the toilet-paper tube test. No dried beans, rice, pasta, buttons, coins, bottle caps, marker caps or other small items, and no plastic bags.

Worth picking up, if you like

The other 11 plays each need one of these 6 low-cost things: an unbreakable baby mirror, clear contact paper, bubble solution and a wand, painter's tape, chunky sidewalk chalk, store-bought play dough. None of them is needed to enjoy the rest of the book.

Favorites and funny moments

PLAYS 1-20

0-1

Birth to 1 year



Faces, voices and first games

This stage at a glance

- 1

Your face is the best toy.
Babies love close faces, voices and touch. Short plays of a few minutes are plenty.
- 2

Watch for "more" and "break".
Looking at you, smiling and kicking often mean "more". Turning away or fussing can mean "a break, please".
- 3

Talk in turns.
Coo back when your baby coos. Leave little gaps so your baby can "answer".
- 4

Floor time counts.
Tummy time, rolling and reaching all happen on a clean floor with a grown-up close by.

TALK MOVE TO LEAN ON

Pause and wait

Say a little, then stop. Count to five in your head and give your child room to answer with a look, a sound, a word or a gesture.

PLAY BASKET

a blanket on the floor · an unbreakable baby mirror · board books · a soft ball · plastic cups and a bowl · a clean dish towel

Just home with a newborn? Start with the plays marked "From birth": Face to face (1), Tummy-time mirror chat (2), Tell the diaper change (3), Hello, Sock! (4), Kick to the beat (5), Kitchen dance party (20), plus Chest chat and This little piggy in **Tired-grown-up plays** (page 77). A few minutes of face-to-face chat is plenty.

In this chapter

1	Face to face	0-6 mo	11	Kitchen band	6-12 mo
2	Tummy-time mirror chat	0-6 mo	12	In and out bucket	8-12 mo
3	Tell the diaper change	0-12 mo	13	Build and crash	6-12 mo
4	Hello, Sock!	0-12 mo	14	Bye-bye, hello!	9-12 mo
5	Kick to the beat	0-6 mo	15	Leaf look	3-12 mo
6	Where's the sound?	3-9 mo	16	Row, row, stop!	6-12 mo
7	Peekaboo towel	4-12 mo	17	Cushion tunnel	8-12 mo
8	Pour and splash	6-12 mo	18	Name-it walk	6-12 mo
9	Rolling ball chase	6-12 mo	19	Point-and-talk book	6-12 mo
10	Pull-out box	6-12 mo	20	Kitchen dance party	0-12 mo

Every child grows at their own pace, and ages here are a guide, not a deadline. If you have questions about how your child is growing, moving or talking, ask your child's doctor.

PLAY 1 **From birth** Best for 0-6 mo

Face to face

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Wind-down

🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 **NOTHING TO BUY**

Hold your baby about a foot from your face. Slowly open your mouth wide, stick out your tongue or raise your eyebrows, then stop and watch. Give your baby time to look, wriggle or try it back.

Make it easier: Just smile and wait. A slow blink or a smile back is a turn.

Make it harder: Add a sound to each face: "ahh" with a wide mouth, "ooh" with round lips.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"You're looking at me! Hello, you."

✅ **Safety:** Support your baby's head and neck. If your baby turns away or fusses, rest and try again later.

PLAY 2 **From birth** Best for 0-6 mo

Tummy-time mirror chat

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: a blanket, an unbreakable baby mirror

Lay your baby on their tummy on a blanket on the floor. Lie down facing them at eye level and prop the mirror to one side. Chat, smile and point to the baby in the mirror.

Make it easier: Lie back and rest your baby on your chest, facing you, for a minute or two.

Make it harder: Slide the mirror a little further away so your baby reaches and pivots toward it.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"Who's that? That's you!"

✅ **Safety:** Tummy time only while your baby is awake and you are watching. Babies always sleep on their backs.

03



PLAY 3 From birth Best for 0-12 mo

Tell the diaper change

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors
 📦 You need: *Nothing but you*

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Turn a daily job into a chat. Say each step as you do it, slowly and warmly. Pause after each step, as if your baby were answering you, and smile at every coo.

Make it easier: Name one step each time: "Clean diaper!"

Make it harder: Add a song to one step, like a "clean diaper" tune, and sing it every time.

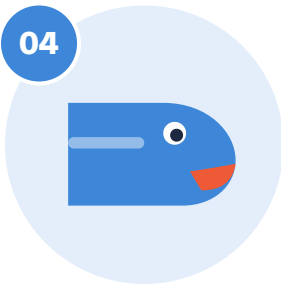
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"Cold wipe! Brr. Now a clean diaper. All done!"

✅ **Safety:** Keep one hand on your baby on a changing table and never step away, even for a second.

04



PLAY 4 From birth Best for 0-12 mo

Hello, Sock!

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors
 📦 You need: a clean adult sock

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Pull the sock over your hand to make a puppet. Let it peek out from behind your back, say hello in a funny voice and gently tickle your baby's toes. Hide it and bring it back.

Make it easier: Keep Sock still and let your baby look at it and reach for it.

Make it harder: Let Sock "hide" under a blanket and ask your baby to find it.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture



"Hi, baby! I'm Sock. Where are your toes?"

✅ **Safety:** Use a plain sock with nothing sewn on. Buttons and stick-on eyes can come off.

05



PLAY 5 From birth Best for 0-6 mo

Kick to the beat

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy
 📦 You need: *Nothing but you*

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Lay your baby on their back. Hold both feet softly and move them like bicycle pedals while you sing. Stop the song, wait, then start again when your baby wiggles.

Make it easier: Move one foot at a time, slowly, in time with your song.

Make it harder: Try fast kicks and slow kicks, and name them as you go.

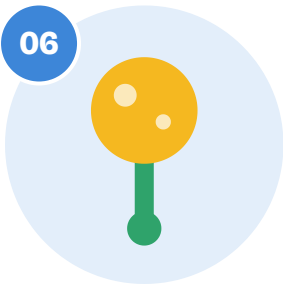
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture



“Kick, kick, kick your feet, kick them to the beat!”

✅ **Safety:** Move gently and let your baby lead. Stop if your baby stiffens or fusses.

06



PLAY 6 From 3 mo Best for 3-9 mo

Where's the sound?

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors
 📦 You need: a baby rattle

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Shake the rattle softly on one side of your baby, out of sight. Wait for your baby to turn and find it, then cheer. Try the other side, then above.

Make it easier: Shake the rattle where your baby can see it first, then move it slowly to one side.

Make it harder: Use two different sounds and see which one your baby turns to first.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



“Shake, shake! Where is it? There it is!”

✅ **Safety:** Use a rattle made for babies. No homemade shakers filled with rice or beads: lids can open.

07



PLAY 7 From 4 mo Best for 4-12 mo

Peekaboo towel

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: a small dish towel

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Hide your face behind the towel, wait a moment and pop out with a smile. Later, drape the towel over a teddy and let your baby pull it off to find it.

Make it easier: Cover your eyes with your hands instead of the towel, and keep the wait short.

Make it harder: Hide a toy completely under the towel and let your baby search.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



“Where did I go? ... Boo! Here I am!”

✅ **Safety:** Hide your own face or a toy. Never cover your baby's face.

08



PLAY 8 From 6 mo Best for 6-12 mo

Pour and splash

🕒 No prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Bath time

🛒 You need: a plastic cup, bath toys

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

At bath time, pour water slowly over your baby's hand or tummy. Say "pour" as it flows and "splash" when you pat the water together. Let your baby hold the cup.

Make it easier: Trickle a little water over your baby's hand and say "drip, drip".

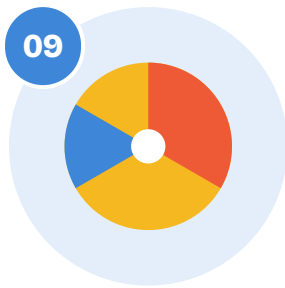
Make it harder: Pour from high and low, and say "big splash" and "little splash".

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



“Pour... pour... SPLASH!”

✅ **Safety:** Stay within arm's reach the whole time. Keep the water shallow and lukewarm, and never leave, even for a moment.



PLAY 9 From 6 mo Best for 6-12 mo

Rolling ball chase

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy

🛒 You need: a soft ball bigger than a fist

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Sit your baby up with support and roll the ball slowly toward them. For a crawler, roll it just ahead so they can go and get it. Cheer every catch.

Make it easier: Put the ball in your baby's hands and help them push it away.

Make it harder: Roll the ball back and forth and say "my turn, your turn".

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"Ball! Rolling... rolling... you got it!"

✅ **Safety:** The ball must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.



PLAY 10 From 6 mo Best for 6-12 mo

Pull-out box

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: an empty tissue box, 4-5 washcloths

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Stuff the washcloths into the empty box so a corner of one peeks out. Your baby pulls them out one by one. Stuff them back in and play again.

Make it easier: Leave half of each washcloth sticking out so it's easy to grab.

Make it harder: Use washcloths in two colors and name each color as it comes out.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"Pull! Out it comes. Another one?"

✅ **Safety:** Take the plastic film off the box opening first, and stay close so the box doesn't get chewed.



11

PLAY 11 From 6 mo Best for 6-12 mo

Kitchen band

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Kitchen

🛒 You need: a pot, a wooden spoon

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Turn a pot upside down on the floor and tap it with the spoon. Then give your baby a turn. Copy whatever rhythm your baby makes, then play "stop" and "go".

Make it easier: Put your hand over your baby's and tap together, slowly.

Make it harder: Add a second "drum" (a plastic bowl) and name loud and quiet.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture



"Bang, bang! ... Stop! ... Bang!"

✅ **Safety:** Play on the floor, well away from the stove, hot pans and hot drinks.



12

PLAY 12 From 8 mo Best for 8-12 mo

In and out bucket

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: a big bowl or bucket, 4-6 large toys

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Drop a toy into the bucket with a big "in!". Tip them all out with an "out!". Hand your baby a toy and wait to see what they do with it.

Make it easier: Just do "out": fill the bucket yourself and let your baby tip it over.

Make it harder: Use a container with a smaller opening so it takes more aiming.

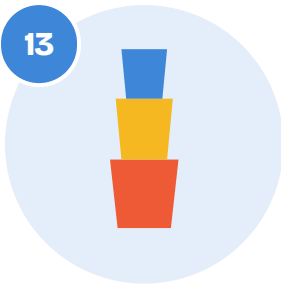
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



"In! ... In it goes. Out!"

✅ **Safety:** Every toy must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

13



PLAY 13 From 6 mo Best for 6-12 mo

Build and crash

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: stacking cups or plastic cups

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Stack a small tower in front of your baby. Stop before the top cup and wait, then let your baby knock it all down. Build again, as many times as they like.

Make it easier: Build a tower of just two cups.

Make it harder: Build the tower higher and count each cup out loud.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



“Up, up, up... (wait) CRASH!”

✅ **Safety:** Use sturdy plastic cups that won't crack into sharp pieces.

14



PLAY 14 From 9 mo Best for 9-12 mo

Bye-bye, hello!

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: 2-3 favorite toys

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Wave "bye-bye" as a toy hides behind your back. Bring it back with a big "hello!" and a wave. Soon your baby may wave along.

Make it easier: Hide the toy for just a second, then bring it straight back.

Make it harder: Hide toys in more places: under a cushion, behind the sofa.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture



“Bye-bye, duck! ... Hello, duck!”

✅ **Safety:** Play on the floor, clear of stairs and sharp furniture corners.

15



PLAY 15 From 3 mo Best for 3-12 mo

Leaf look

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Outdoors

🛒 You need: a big leaf you find outside

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Carry your baby outside and look up at leaves moving in the wind. Hold a big leaf for your baby to see and feel. Swish it gently and name it.

Make it easier: Stand under a tree together and watch the leaves move.

Make it harder: Collect three different leaves and compare big, small, smooth and bumpy.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



“Leaf. Green leaf. It goes swish!”

✅ **Safety:** You hold the leaf. Keep your baby in the shade, dressed for the weather, and check that nothing goes in mouths.

16



PLAY 16 From 6 mo Best for 6-12 mo

Row, row, stop!

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Waiting & car

🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Sit your baby on your lap facing you. Rock gently while you sing "Row, Row, Row Your Boat" or any rocking song your family knows. Stop just before the last word and wait. Finish the line with a smile.

Make it easier: Sing the whole song with no stop, rocking slowly.

Make it harder: Swap in a new animal ("Row, row, row your... duck!") and act it out.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



“Row, row, row your... (wait) ...boat!”

✅ **Safety:** Support your baby's back and head. Gentle rocking only.



17

PLAY 17 From 8 mo Best for 8-12 mo

Cushion tunnel

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy

🛒 You need: sofa cushions or a large open box

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Lay cushions on the floor as a path, or open both ends of a big box to make a tunnel. Wait at the far end and call your baby through.

Make it easier: Skip the tunnel: lie on the floor and let your baby crawl over your legs.

Make it harder: Add a cushion "hill" to climb over at the end of the tunnel.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"You're crawling... through... and OUT!"

✅ **Safety:** Cushions stay flat on the floor. Take staples and tape off boxes.



18

PLAY 18 From 6 mo Best for 6-12 mo

Name-it walk

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Carry your baby around your home. Stop at things your baby looks at, touch them together and name them: light, door, window, plant.

Make it easier: Stop at just one thing, like the light, and name it every time you pass.

Make it harder: Stop at the same three things every day and let your baby point first.

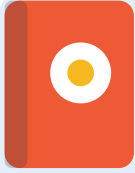
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"Light. On! ... Off!"

✅ **Safety:** Keep little fingers away from outlets, cords and anything hot.

19



PLAY 19 From 6 mo Best for 6-12 mo

Point-and-talk book

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Wind-down

📦 You need: a sturdy board book

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Skip the words on the page. Point to a picture, name it and make its sound. Let your baby turn the pages, hold the book and choose where to look.

Make it easier: Choose a book with one big picture on each page.

Make it harder: Pause before turning each page and let your baby say or sign "more".

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



"Dog! Woof, woof. Where's the dog?"

✅ **Safety:** Board books only at this age. Paper pages can tear into mouth-sized bits.

20



PLAY 20 From birth Best for 0-12 mo

Kitchen dance party

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Kitchen · Big energy

📦 You need: music you like (optional)

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Hold your baby close and sway, step and turn to music or your own singing. Stop, wait for a wiggle, then dance again.

Make it easier: Just sway slowly and hum.

Make it harder: Freeze when the music stops, then start again when your baby wiggles.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture



"Sway, sway... and turn!"

✅ **Safety:** Support head and neck. Slow, gentle moves away from the stove. Never shake or bounce hard.



OUR OWN PLAY

age: _____

🕒 ☐ No prep ☐ 2 min ☐ 10 min ☒ ☐ None ☐ A little ☐ Messy ⌚ ☐ 5 ☐ 10 ☐ 20+

🛒 You need: _____

HOW TO PLAY

Easier: _____ Harder: _____

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY



✓ Safety: _____



OUR OWN PLAY

age: _____

🕒 ☐ No prep ☐ 2 min ☐ 10 min ☒ ☐ None ☐ A little ☐ Messy ⌚ ☐ 5 ☐ 10 ☐ 20+

🛒 You need: _____

HOW TO PLAY

Easier: _____ Harder: _____

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY



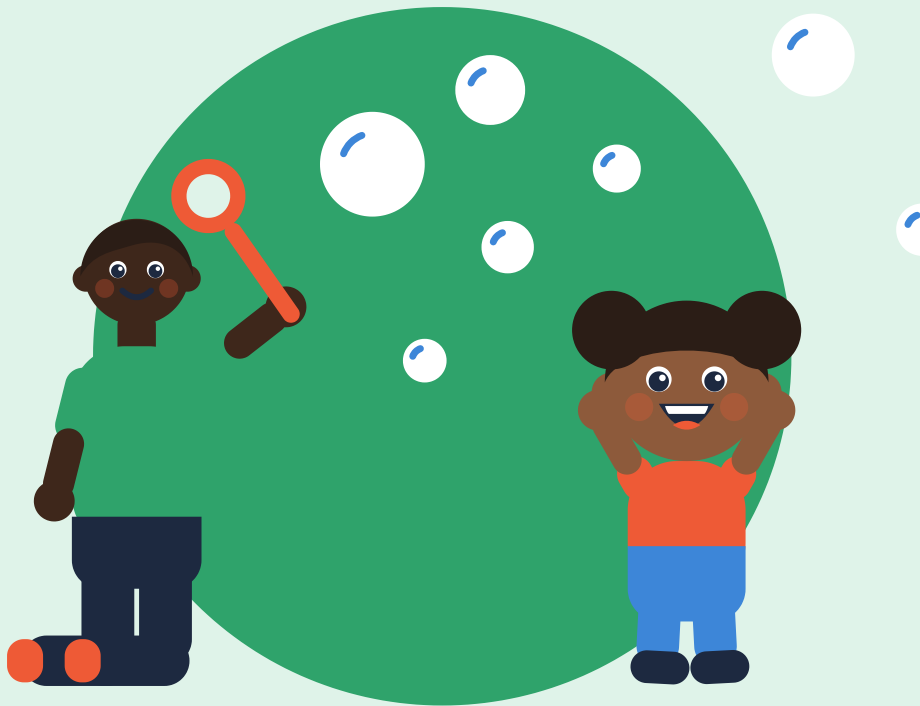
✓ Safety: _____

Favorites and funny moments

PLAYS 21-45

1-2

1 to 2 years



On the move and into everything

This stage at a glance

- 1

Same play, many times.
Toddlers love to repeat. Doing a play again and again is part of the fun.
- 2

Short words win.
Use one to three words at a time, say them often and add one more word to what your child says.
- 3

In, out, up, down.
Filling, dumping, pushing and climbing are big favorites. Set up safe ways to do them.
- 4

Tiny things stay away.
Everything in reach must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

TALK MOVE TO LEAN ON

Repeat and add one

When your child says or shows something, say it back and add one more word: "Ball." "Big ball!"

PLAY BASKET

a laundry basket · large cardboard boxes · a big bowl or bucket · painter's tape · plastic tubs with lids · a pot and a wooden spoon

In this chapter

21	Posting box	12-24 mo	34	Laundry helper	18-24 mo
22	Laundry basket ride	12-24 mo	35	Tape peel	18-24 mo
23	Sticky wall	12-24 mo	36	Flying high	12-24 mo
24	Big sock, little sock	18-24 mo	37	Snack choice	12-24 mo
25	Water painting	18-24 mo	38	Mirror faces	12-24 mo
26	Bubble chase	12-24 mo	39	Push it along	12-18 mo
27	Which cup?	12-24 mo	40	This is the way...	12-24 mo
28	Animal sounds	12-24 mo	41	Nature bag walk	18-24 mo
29	Box car	12-24 mo	42	Knock, knock!	18-24 mo
30	Pillow mountain	18-24 mo	43	Pots and lids	18-24 mo
31	Wash the baby doll	18-24 mo	44	Follow me, follow you	12-24 mo
32	Scoop and pour	18-24 mo	45	Pretend phone call	18-24 mo
33	Ramp race	18-24 mo			

Every child grows at their own pace, and ages here are a guide, not a deadline. If you have questions about how your child is growing, moving or talking, ask your child's doctor.

21



PLAY 21 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Posting box

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

🛠 You need: a shoebox, large plastic lids

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Cut a wide slot in the shoebox lid. Show your toddler how to push a lid through the slot: clunk! Take turns until the box is full, then tip it out and start again.

Make it easier: Take the lid off the box and drop the big lids straight in.

Make it harder: Cut a second slot and sort the lids by color. Every lid still passes the tube test.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



"In! Clunk! More?"

✓ **Safety:** Every lid must be bigger than a toilet-paper tube opening. Tape over any rough cut edges.

22



PLAY 22 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Laundry basket ride

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy

🛠 You need: a laundry basket

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Your toddler sits in the empty basket. Say "ready, set..." and wait for them to say or show "go". Push slowly around the room and stop, then go again.

Make it easier: Keep the basket still: your toddler climbs in and out while you say "in!" and "out!"

Make it harder: Let a teddy ride too and give your toddler the "go" and "stop" jobs.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"Ready, set... (wait) GO! ... Stop!"

✓ **Safety:** Push slowly on a flat floor, away from stairs. Your child stays sitting down.

23



PLAY 23 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Sticky wall

⌚ 10-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: clear contact paper, tape, big paper shapes or leaves

Tape contact paper to the wall at toddler height, sticky side out. Your toddler presses big shapes or leaves onto it, pulls them off and sticks them again.

Make it easier: Lay the contact paper flat on the floor, sticky side up, taped at the corners.

Make it harder: Stick up big shapes in two colors and name each color as it goes on.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



“Stick! ... Pull it off! Stick it again.”

✓ **Safety:** Every piece must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube. Watch that paper doesn't go in mouths.

24



PLAY 24 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Big sock, little sock

⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: a pile of clean socks

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Tip out a pile of grown-up and child socks. Sort them together into two piles: big and little. Hold one up and wait for your toddler to show you where it goes.

Make it easier: Use just two socks: one big, one little.

Make it harder: Try matching pairs: find the sock that looks the same.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“Big sock... little sock. Whose is it?”

✓ **Safety:** Socks only. Keep laundry pods and detergent locked away and out of reach.

25



PLAY 25 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Water painting

🕒 No prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Outdoors

🛒 You need: a cup of water, a clean paintbrush

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Outside, dip the brush in water and "paint" a fence, a step or the sidewalk. Watch the marks shrink and disappear in the sun. Paint again!

Make it easier: Dip your fingers in the water and "paint" with them instead of a brush.

Make it harder: Paint big lines, then little dots, and name each shape.

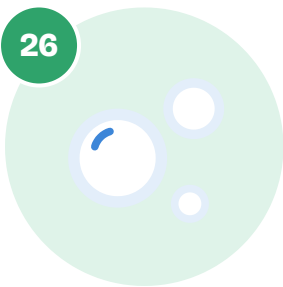
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"Paint, paint... it's gone! The sun dried it."

✅ **Safety:** Stay with your child near any water, even a cup. Pick a shady spot on a hot day.

26



PLAY 26 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Bubble chase

🕒 No prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Outdoors · Big energy

🛒 You need: bubble solution and a wand

You blow the bubbles; your toddler chases, claps and pops them. Wait before each new round so your toddler can ask for more with a look, a sign or a word.

Make it easier: Blow a few bubbles low down, where they're easy to reach and pop.

Make it harder: Count the bubbles your toddler pops: "one, two, three pops!"

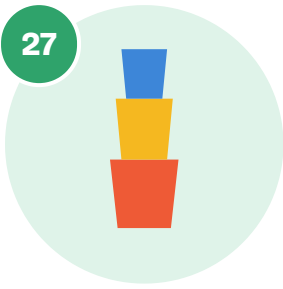
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



"Big bubble or lots of bubbles?"

✅ **Safety:** The grown-up holds the bottle. Bubble mix is not for drinking; rinse eyes with water if it splashes.

27



PLAY 27 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Which cup?

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 **You need:** 2-3 plastic cups, a toy too big for a toilet-paper tube

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Hide the toy under one cup while your toddler watches. Ask where it went. Lift the cups together. Later, let your toddler hide it for you to find.

Make it easier: Use one cup: hide the toy and lift it with a "there it is!"

Make it harder: Use three cups and slide them around slowly before lifting.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"Where's duck? Under this one?"

✓ **Safety:** The toy must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

28



PLAY 28 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Animal sounds

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Waiting & car

🛒 **You need:** toy animals or an animal picture book

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Hold up an animal and make its sound. Next time, start the line and wait for your toddler to fill in the sound. Any sound they make counts.

Make it easier: Stick to two animals your toddler already loves.

Make it harder: Add an action to each sound: flap for "quack", stomp for "moo".

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"The cow says... (wait) ...moo!"

✓ **Safety:** Toy animals must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

29



PLAY 29 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Box car

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy

🛒 You need: a big cardboard box

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Your toddler sits in the box: now it's a car. Push it slowly and make "beep beep" sounds. Stop at pretend places like the park or the shop.

Make it easier: Leave the box still and pretend to steer: "beep beep!"

Make it harder: Build a "car wash" from a blanket to drive through.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



"Beep beep! Park or shop?"

✅ **Safety:** Take off staples and packing tape. Push slowly on a flat floor.

30



PLAY 30 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Pillow mountain

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy

🛒 You need: pillows and sofa cushions

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Pile pillows on the floor into a soft mountain. Your toddler climbs up, rolls down and does it again. Cheer at the top!

Make it easier: Make a small hill of two cushions.

Make it harder: Add a "tunnel" under a table to crawl through after the mountain.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



"Up the mountain... and down!"

✅ **Safety:** Floor level only, away from furniture corners, windows and stairs. Never pile pillows in a crib.

31



PLAY 31 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Wash the baby doll

🕒 2-min prep 💧 Messy ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Bath time · Kitchen

🛒 **You need:** a doll or plastic animals, a washcloth, a shallow tub of water

🏠 **NOTHING TO BUY**

Give the doll a bath together. Name each part as you wash it: tummy, feet, hair. Dry it with a towel and tuck it in.

Make it easier: Skip the water: "wash" the doll with a dry cloth and name each part.

Make it harder: Name body parts in order: "head, shoulders, knees and toes".

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



"Wash her tummy. Now her feet. Wet feet!"

✓ **Safety:** An inch or two of water, and stay within arm's reach. Every toy too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube. Tip the water out as soon as you finish.

32



PLAY 32 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Scoop and pour

🕒 2-min prep 💧 Messy ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Indoors · Kitchen

🛒 **You need:** a big tub, rolled oats, cups and spoons

🏠 **NOTHING TO BUY**

Pour a few cups of rolled oats into a big tub with cups and spoons. Scoop, pour, fill and empty together. Put a sheet or towel underneath for easy cleanup.

Make it easier: Use just one big cup and one bowl. If your child doesn't like the feel of the oats, a spoon is fine.

Make it harder: Hide a large toy in the oats and dig for treasure together.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



"Scoop... pour! Full. Now empty."

✓ **Safety:** Rolled oats only. No dried beans, rice or pasta for under-3s. Sit with your child the whole time.

33



PLAY 33 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Ramp race

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: a cushion or baking tray, a ball

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Prop a cushion or tray on a few books to make a low slope. Hold the ball at the top, say "ready...", wait, then let it go. Take turns.

Make it easier: Roll the ball down a slope you hold with your hands.

Make it harder: Try two ramps, one steep and one gentle, and race the balls.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"Ready... (wait) GO! Down it goes."

✓ **Safety:** Keep the ramp low and steady. Balls must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

34



PLAY 34 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Laundry helper

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: clean laundry, a basket

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Your toddler pulls clean clothes out of the dryer or pile and drops them in the basket. Name each one and guess whose it is.

Make it easier: Hand over one item at a time and name it.

Make it harder: Sort into two piles: shirts and socks, or big and little.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"Shirt! A big blue shirt. In it goes."

✓ **Safety:** Check the dryer is off and cool. Keep detergent and laundry pods locked away.



35

PLAY 35 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Tape peel

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Waiting & car
 🛠 You need: painter's tape

Stick strips of painter's tape on a table or tray, each with one end folded over as a tab. Your toddler peels them off. Stick them on your arm next!

Make it easier: Fold a bigger tab on each strip so it's easy to pinch.

Make it harder: Stick tape in a zig-zag or a square and name the shape.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"Pull... pull... OFF! Another one?"

✓ **Safety:** Crumpled tape can end up in mouths. Collect each piece as it comes off.



36

PLAY 36 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Flying high

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy
 🛠 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Lie on your back on the floor. Hold your toddler firmly under the arms and lift them gently over you like a plane. Fly up, pause, then land for a cuddle.

Make it easier: Sit on the floor with your toddler on your knees and do a gentle "up... and down".

Make it harder: Add a countdown before lift-off: "three, two, one... up!"

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"Up... up... (wait) ...and LAND!"

✓ **Safety:** Low and slow over a soft floor. Hold firmly under the arms, never by the hands or wrists. A grown-up does the lifting, never a big brother or sister.

37



PLAY 37 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Snack choice

⌚ 2-min prep



A little mess



Plays about 5 min



Kitchen

🛒 You need: two snack options

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

At snack time, hold up two options, one in each hand. Name them, then wait. A point, a reach or a word are all answers. Say the word back.

Make it easier: Offer one snack and wait for a reach or a look before you hand it over.

Make it harder: Put both choices in a paper bag and let your toddler reach in and name one.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“Banana or toast? (wait) Toast! Yummy toast.”

✓ **Safety:** Check for food allergies first. Soft food cut small. No whole grapes, nuts, popcorn, raw apple or hard candy. Your child sits to eat.

38



PLAY 38 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Mirror faces

⌚ No prep



No mess



Plays about 5 min



Indoors

🛒 You need: an unbreakable mirror

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Sit in front of a mirror together. Make a happy face, a sad face and a surprised face, and name each one. Copy the faces your toddler makes.

Make it easier: Make one face at a time, starting with happy, and wait for a smile.

Make it harder: Try silly faces too: puffed cheeks, a big tongue, one eye shut.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



“Happy face! ... Now sad. Oh no!”

✓ **Safety:** Use an unbreakable mirror, or one fixed firmly to the wall.

39



PLAY 39 From 12 mo Best for 12-18 mo

Push it along

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy

🛒 You need: a sturdy box or laundry basket, a few toys

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Load a few toys into a box. Your toddler pushes it across the room to "deliver" them to you or to a teddy. Unload, reload and go again.

Make it easier: Push the box together, your hands next to theirs.

Make it harder: Add a stop sign: when you hold up your hand, the box stops.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



"Push! Push! Where to next?"

✓ **Safety:** Clear a path and keep well away from stairs.

40



PLAY 40 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

This is the way...

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Bath time · Indoors

🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Sing along to daily jobs: "This is the way we wash our hands... brush our teeth... put on shoes". Add a hand move for each one and slow down for your toddler to join in.

Make it easier: Sing one verse, the hand-washing one, every day.

Make it harder: Make up a new verse for each part of the day.

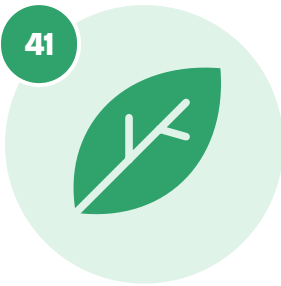
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture



"This is the way we wash our... (wait) ...hands!"

✓ **Safety:** Check the water temperature before little hands go under the tap.

41



PLAY 41 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Nature bag walk

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Outdoors

🛒 You need: a paper bag

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Take a slow walk and collect big treasures in the bag: leaves, pinecones, a long piece of bark. At home, tip them out and talk about each one.

Make it easier: Pick up one big leaf and look at it together. No bag needed.

Make it harder: Sort your treasures at home: leaves in one pile, pinecones in another.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



“Leaf! Big leaf. Put it in.”

✅ **Safety:** Only things too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube. No berries, mushrooms or small stones. Wash hands after.

42



PLAY 42 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Knock, knock!

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: a box or a door, a few toys

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Hide a toy behind a door or inside a box. Knock three times and wait. Open it slowly and say who is there. Let your toddler hide one for you.

Make it easier: Hide the toy behind your back and knock on the floor.

Make it harder: Knock loud and knock quiet, and let your toddler copy.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



“Knock, knock... who’s there? (wait) It’s Bear!”

✅ **Safety:** Watch little fingers near door hinges. A box works just as well.

43



PLAY 43 From 18 mo Best for 18-24 mo

Pots and lids

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Kitchen
 🛒 You need: 3 pots with lids

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Set out cool pots and their lids on the floor. Your toddler finds the lid that fits each pot. Try the wrong one on purpose and act surprised.

Make it easier: Start with one pot and one lid.

Make it harder: Add a wooden spoon to stir with once the lids are on.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



“Too big! ... This one? Yes!”

✓ **Safety:** Clean, cool pots on the floor, away from the stove.

44



PLAY 44 From 12 mo Best for 12-24 mo

Follow me, follow you

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy
 🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Crawl around the room and invite your toddler to follow. Then swap: follow them wherever they go, copying their moves and sounds.

Make it easier: Just follow your toddler and copy what they do.

Make it harder: Take turns being the leader and add a new move each time.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“You go first! I’m coming...”

✓ **Safety:** Clear the floor and gate the stairs.

45



PLAY 45

From 18 mo

Best for 18-24 mo

Pretend phone call

🕒 No prep

💧 No mess

⌚ Plays about 5 min

📍 Indoors · Waiting & car

🛒 You need: a big block or a toy phone

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Hold a block to your ear: "Ring, ring!" Pretend to talk to Grandma or a teddy, then hand it over. Pause for your toddler's turn to "talk".

Make it easier: Say "Ring, ring! Hello!" and hand it over. That's the whole call.

Make it harder: Call a different teddy each time and ask what it wants for dinner.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



"Ring, ring! Hello? It's Grandma! Say hi!"

✓ **Safety:** Use a block or a toy phone. Keep real phones, remote controls and button batteries out of reach.



OUR OWN PLAY

age: _____

🕒 ☐ No prep ☐ 2 min ☐ 10 min ☒ 5 min ☐ None ☐ A little ☐ Messy ⌚ ☐ 5 ☐ 10 ☐ 20+

🛒 You need: _____

HOW TO PLAY

Easier: _____ Harder: _____

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY



✓ **Safety:** _____



OUR OWN PLAY

age: _____

🕒 ☐ No prep ☐ 2 min ☐ 10 min ☒ ☐ None ☐ A little ☐ Messy ⌚ ☐ 5 ☐ 10 ☐ 20+

🛒 You need: _____

HOW TO PLAY

Easier: _____ Harder: _____

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY



✓ Safety: _____



OUR OWN PLAY

age: _____

🕒 ☐ No prep ☐ 2 min ☐ 10 min ☒ ☐ None ☐ A little ☐ Messy ⌚ ☐ 5 ☐ 10 ☐ 20+

🛒 You need: _____

HOW TO PLAY

Easier: _____ Harder: _____

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY



✓ Safety: _____

PLAYS 46-70

2-3

2 to 3 years



Pretend play and "me do it!"

This stage at a glance

- 1

Pretend begins.
Feeding a teddy, making "soup" and driving a box car are all pretend play. Join in with a small role.
- 2

Choices help.
Two good choices ("red cup or blue cup?") let your child be in charge without a battle.
- 3

Big feelings, big moves.
Running, jumping and stomping are part of the day. Plan a movement play when energy is high.
- 4

Still under 3.
Keep the small-parts rule: nothing that fits through a toilet-paper tube, and no marker caps within reach.

TALK MOVE TO LEAN ON

Offer a choice

Hold up two options and wait. Pointing, reaching and looking all count as answers.

PLAY BASKET

chunky crayons and big paper · sidewalk chalk
· a pillowcase · toy pots, cups and a teapot · a flashlight · rain boots

In this chapter

46	Big-box house	2-3 yrs	59	Teddy's bedtime	2-3 yrs
47	Color sort	2-3 yrs	60	Float or sink?	2-3 yrs
48	Soup kitchen	2-3 yrs	61	Stomp and tiptoe	2-3 yrs
49	Toy wash	2-3 yrs	62	Shoe match	2-3 yrs
50	Living-room obstacle course	2-3 yrs	63	Count the tower	2-3 yrs
51	Tape road	2-3 yrs	64	Hot and cold hunt	2-3 yrs
52	Freeze dance	2-3 yrs	65	Tea party	2-3 yrs
53	Shadow shapes	2-3 yrs	66	Photo stories	2-3 yrs
54	Mystery bag	2-3 yrs	67	Plate-wheel drive	2-3 yrs
55	Corner shop	2-3 yrs	68	Giant floor mural	2-3 yrs
56	Puddle jumping	2-3 yrs	69	Counting stairs	2-3 yrs
57	Chalk outlines	2-3 yrs	70	Finish the rhyme	2-3 yrs
58	Salad helper	2-3 yrs			

Every child grows at their own pace, and ages here are a guide, not a deadline. If you have questions about how your child is growing, moving or talking, ask your child's doctor.

46



PLAY 46 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Big-box house

🕒 10-min prep 💧💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: a large cardboard box, chunky crayons

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

The grown-up cuts a door and a window in the box. Your child decorates it with crayons, moves in teddies and invites you to visit.

Make it easier: Skip the cutting: tip the box on its side and it's a house already.

Make it harder: Add a mailbox slot so teddies can post you letters.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



"Knock, knock! Can I come in your house?"

✅ **Safety:** The grown-up does all the cutting. Take off staples and tape first.

47



PLAY 47 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Color sort

🕒 2-min prep 💧💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: 3 colored bowls or paper sheets, toys in those colors

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Put down one bowl or sheet for each color. Your child sorts toys onto the matching color. Mix them up and go again, or race a timer song.

Make it easier: Use two colors only.

Make it harder: Add a fourth color, or sort by size instead of color.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



"Red block... where does it go?"

✅ **Safety:** Every toy must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

48



PLAY 48 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Soup kitchen

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Kitchen

🛒 You need: a pot, a spoon, blocks or toy food

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Your child makes pretend soup: blocks go in, stir, stir, stir. You are the hungry customer. Taste it, ask for more salt, and let your child serve the teddies too.

Make it easier: Just stir and taste together: "Mmm, yummy!"

Make it harder: Write a pretend menu with pictures and let your child take your order.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



"Mmm! What's in my soup today?"

✅ **Safety:** Pretend food only, and nothing that fits through a toilet-paper tube. The real stove stays off-limits.

49



PLAY 49 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Toy wash

🕒 2-min prep 💧 Messy ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Outdoors · Kitchen

🛒 You need: a tub of soapy water, a sponge, plastic toys

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Set up a toy "wash" outside or on a towel. Your child scrubs plastic toys and cars, rinses them and lines them up to dry in the sun.

Make it easier: Wash one toy together with a damp cloth, on a towel.

Make it harder: Line up the clean toys from biggest to smallest.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



"Scrub, scrub! Is it clean or dirty?"

✅ **Safety:** Shallow water, mild soap and a grown-up right there. Big toys only: nothing that fits through a toilet-paper tube. Tip the water out when you finish.

50



PLAY 50 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Living-room obstacle course

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy

🔑 You need: cushions, a chair, painter's tape

Make a short course: climb over cushions, crawl under a chair, walk along a tape line, jump at the end. Do it together, then let your child change the order.

Make it easier: Make a course of two steps: over a cushion, then a jump.

Make it harder: Time the course with a song and try to finish before it ends.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



"Over... under... through! What's next?"

✅ **Safety:** Everything at floor level with a soft landing. No climbing on furniture.

51



PLAY 51 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Tape road

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

🔑 You need: painter's tape, big toy cars

Tape a road across the floor with bends and a parking spot. Drive cars along it together. Add a "stop" corner and a car wash made from a box.

Make it easier: Tape one straight road and drive back and forth.

Make it harder: Add a bridge (a book) and a tunnel (a box) to the road.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"Vroom! Turn... and STOP at the corner!"

✅ **Safety:** Use big toy cars. Tiny cars and their wheels are a choking risk for under-3s.

52



PLAY 52 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Freeze dance

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy
 📦 You need: music

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Play music and dance. When the music stops, everyone freezes like a statue. Try silly freezes: frozen on one leg, frozen with a funny face.

Make it easier: Hold hands and freeze together.

Make it harder: Freeze in the shape of an animal and guess what each other is.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture



“Dance... dance... FREEZE!”

✅ **Safety:** Clear toys off the floor first so nobody trips.

53



PLAY 53 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Shadow shapes

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Wind-down
 📦 You need: a flashlight

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

In a dim room, shine the flashlight on a wall. Make hand shadows: a bird, a bunny, a big mouth. Let your child hold their hands in the light and see what appears.

Make it easier: Shine the light on a teddy and make its shadow big and small.

Make it harder: Tell a short story with your shadow animals.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“Look, a bird! Flap, flap. Your turn!”

✅ **Safety:** The grown-up holds the flashlight. Keep battery covers screwed shut.

54



PLAY 54 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Mystery bag

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Waiting & car

🛒 You need: a pillowcase, 4 familiar objects

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Put a spoon, a sock, a block and a ball in the pillowcase. Your child reaches in, feels one and guesses before pulling it out.

Make it easier: Use two very different things, like a sock and a spoon, and let your child peek.

Make it harder: Put in two things that feel alike, such as two spoons of different sizes.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“Is it soft or hard? ... What is it?”

✅ **Safety:** Nothing sharp, and everything too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

55



PLAY 55 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Corner shop

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Kitchen

🛒 You need: boxes and cans from the cupboard, a cloth bag or basket

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Line up food boxes and cans on a low shelf. Your child is the shopper with a bag, and you are the shopkeeper. Swap roles next time.

Make it easier: Put three things on the shelf and shop together.

Make it harder: Add a "till": count the items into the bag, one, two, three.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“What do you need today? Pasta or beans?”

✅ **Safety:** Light boxes and small unopened cans only. Keep glass jars away, and use a cloth bag or basket, never a plastic bag.

56



PLAY 56 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Puddle jumping

🕒 No prep 💧💧 Messy ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Outdoors · Big energy

🛒 You need: rain boots, a raincoat

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

After rain, find shallow puddles. Count to three and jump! Try big jumps and little jumps, tiptoe splashes and stomps.

Make it easier: Hold hands and step in together, then stomp.

Make it harder: Measure the splash: mark where the water lands with chalk.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“One, two, three... JUMP! Big splash or little splash?”

✅ **Safety:** Shallow puddles only, away from the road. Stay right beside your child near any water.

57



PLAY 57 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Chalk outlines

🕒 No prep 💧💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Outdoors

🛒 You need: chunky sidewalk chalk

Trace around your child's hands and feet with chalk, then let them trace yours. Add a sun, a house or a road. Stand on the drawings and talk about them.

Make it easier: Trace just one hand each.

Make it harder: Draw a road with chalk and walk it together, stopping at the corners.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



“Your foot is little. My foot is BIG!”

✅ **Safety:** Chunky chalk only, and pick up broken bits. Stay on a path or driveway away from traffic.



58

PLAY 58 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Salad helper

🕒 No prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Kitchen

🛒 You need: lettuce, a big bowl

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Wash hands together. Your child tears lettuce into the bowl and tosses it with big spoons. Name each thing that goes in.

Make it easier: Give your child one big lettuce leaf to tear.

Make it harder: Add one new vegetable to wash and name each time. The grown-up cuts it into soft, small pieces.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“Tear... tear... big piece or little piece?”

✅ **Safety:** No knives at this age: the grown-up does any cutting. Check for allergies before a new food, and your child sits down to eat.



59

PLAY 59 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Teddy's bedtime

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Wind-down

🛒 You need: a teddy, a small blanket, a board book

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Put a teddy to bed: pajamas (a sock!), a pretend brush of the teeth, a story and a song. Ask your child what Teddy needs next.

Make it easier: Cover Teddy with the blanket and sing one song.

Make it harder: Put two toys to bed and give each one a different song.

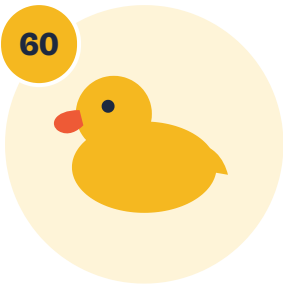
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“Teddy is sleepy. What does Teddy need?”

✅ **Safety:** Use doll clothes without small buttons or beads.

60



PLAY 60 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Float or sink?

🕒 No prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Bath time

🛒 You need: a sponge, a plastic cup, a spoon, a big lid

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

At bath time, hold up each thing and guess together: float or sink? Drop it in and see. Then try to make the floaters sink.

Make it easier: Try two things only: a sponge that floats and a big metal spoon that sinks.

Make it harder: Try to make a floater sink by filling it with water.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



"Float or sink? What do you think?"

✅ **Safety:** Stay within arm's reach the whole time. Use only large objects.

61



PLAY 61 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Stomp and tiptoe

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy

🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Walk like an elephant: stomp and talk in a big voice. Then be a mouse: tiptoe and whisper. Take turns calling out the switch: "Elephant!" ... "Mouse!"

Make it easier: Just stomp together, then stop.

Make it harder: Add a third animal: a hopping bunny or a slithering snake.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture



"Elephant: STOMP, STOMP! ... Mouse: tiptoe..."

✅ **Safety:** Clear the floor. Stomp on the ground floor if neighbors are below!

62



PLAY 62 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Shoe match

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors
🛒 You need: family shoes

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Mix up a pile of family shoes. Your child finds the pairs and guesses whose they are. Try a big shoe on a little foot for a laugh.

Make it easier: Use three pairs of shoes.

Make it harder: Line the shoes up from smallest to biggest.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“Whose big shoe is this? Mine or yours?”

✅ **Safety:** Leave out shoes with long laces, or tie the laces up short.

63



PLAY 63 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Count the tower

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors
🛒 You need: blocks or small boxes

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Build a tower together and count each block as it goes on. Guess how tall it will get before it falls. Knock it down and count again.

Make it easier: Count to three and knock it down.

Make it harder: Guess before you build: “Will it be taller than the chair?”

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



“One, two, three... how tall?”

✅ **Safety:** Light blocks or boxes, so a falling tower can't hurt anyone. Every block too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

64



PLAY 64 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Hot and cold hunt

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors
📦 You need: a favorite toy

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Hide the toy while your child covers their eyes. Give clues as they search: "warm... warmer... HOT!" Then let your child hide it for you.

Make it easier: Hide the toy in plain sight while your child watches.

Make it harder: Use a picture clue: show a drawing of where the toy is hiding.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"You're getting warmer... warmer... HOT!"

✅ **Safety:** Hide things at floor or low-shelf height only.

65



PLAY 65 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Tea party

🕒 No prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Kitchen
📦 You need: cups and a jug, teddies

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Set out cups for everyone, teddies included. Your child pours pretend or cool water and serves. Say "please" and "thank you" in funny teddy voices.

Make it easier: Use empty cups and pour pretend tea only.

Make it harder: Invite a teddy that is "shy" and help your child ask it questions.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"More tea, Bear? (wait) Yes, please!"

✅ **Safety:** Pretend or cool water only, with you right there. No hot drinks nearby.

66



PLAY 66 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Photo stories

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Wind-down
 📁 You need: printed family photos or an album

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Look at family photos together. Point to people and ask what they are doing. Tell the short story of each picture and let your child add their part.

Make it easier: Look at one photo and name the people in it.

Make it harder: Put three photos in order: first, next, last.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“Who’s that? What are they doing?”

✅ **Safety:** Keep glass picture frames up high; use an album or loose prints.

67



PLAY 67 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Plate-wheel drive

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors
 📁 You need: a paper plate, two chairs

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Line up two chairs as car seats and use a paper plate as the steering wheel. Take turns driving to pretend places and describe what you "see" out the window.

Make it easier: Just hold the plate and turn it: "Turn, turn, beep!"

Make it harder: Add a map: draw where you are driving to on paper.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“Where shall we drive? Beach or shop?”

✅ **Safety:** Chairs on a flat floor away from stairs. Sit down together, no standing on chairs.



PLAY 68 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Giant floor mural

🕒 2-min prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: a long sheet of paper, tape, chunky crayons

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Tape a long sheet of paper to the floor. Lie down and draw side by side. Talk about the marks: zig-zags, dots, big circles. Copy each other's lines.

Make it easier: Use one crayon and one sheet of paper.

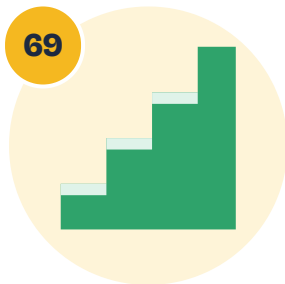
Make it harder: Draw each other's outline on the paper and color in the clothes.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"You made a zig-zag! I'll make a circle."

✅ **Safety:** Chunky crayons only. Pick up broken bits and keep marker caps away.



PLAY 69 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Counting stairs

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Indoors · Outdoors

🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Hold hands and count out loud as you climb steps at home or outside. Stop before a number and wait for your child to say it or step it.

Make it easier: Count to three, then start again.

Make it harder: Count backwards on the way down.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"One... two... (wait) ...three!"

✅ **Safety:** Hold hands on stairs and use the rail. Keep baby gates closed afterward.

70



PLAY 70 From 24 mo Best for 2-3 yrs

Finish the rhyme

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Waiting & car · Wind-down

🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

On a car ride or in a waiting room, sing nursery rhymes your child knows. Leave off the last word of a line and wait for your child to fill it in.

Make it easier: Leave off the last word in the one rhyme your child knows best.

Make it harder: Switch to rhymes with actions and leave off the action word.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



“Twinkle, twinkle, little... (wait) ...star!”

✓ **Safety:** In the car, your child is buckled into a properly fitted car seat and the driver keeps eyes on the road.



OUR OWN PLAY

age: _____

🕒 ☐ No prep ☐ 2 min ☐ 10 min 💧 ☐ None ☐ A little ☐ Messy ⌚ ☐ 5 ☐ 10 ☐ 20+

🛒 You need: _____

HOW TO PLAY

Easier: _____ Harder: _____

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY



✓ **Safety:** _____



OUR OWN PLAY

age: _____

🕒 ☐ No prep ☐ 2 min ☐ 10 min ☒ ☐ None ☐ A little ☐ Messy ⌚ ☐ 5 ☐ 10 ☐ 20+



You need: _____

HOW TO PLAY

Easier: _____ Harder: _____

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY





Safety: _____



OUR OWN PLAY

age: _____

🕒 ☐ No prep ☐ 2 min ☐ 10 min ☒ ☐ None ☐ A little ☐ Messy ⌚ ☐ 5 ☐ 10 ☐ 20+



You need: _____

HOW TO PLAY

Easier: _____ Harder: _____

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY





Safety: _____

PLAYS 71-100

3-5

3 to 5 years



Big ideas, stories and rules

This stage at a glance

- 1 Stories everywhere.**
Preschoolers love to make things up. Ask "and then what?" and let the story run.
- 2 Games with rules.**
Simple rule games like "freeze" or "Simon says" are a big hit. Keep them short and silly.
- 3 Real jobs.**
Helping to cook, sort and fix feels important. Give real, safe jobs with a grown-up close by.
- 4 Mind the little ones.**
Some plays here use small items that are fine for 3+ but not for babies and toddlers nearby.

TALK MOVE TO LEAN ON

Follow their lead

Let your child choose what to do and how. Join in, copy them and talk about their idea.

PLAY BASKET

a big cardboard box · a blanket and chairs · store-bought play dough · paper, tape and crayons · dress-up hats and bags · a notebook for plans

In this chapter

71	Box rocket	3–5 yrs	86	Pasta tower	3–5 yrs
72	Blanket fort	3–5 yrs	87	Feelings faces	3–5 yrs
73	I spy colors	3–5 yrs	88	Measure with feet	3–5 yrs
74	Scavenger hunt	3–5 yrs	89	Little gardeners	3–5 yrs
75	Play-dough bakery	3–5 yrs	90	Paper plane contest	3–5 yrs
76	Simon says	3–5 yrs	91	Puppet show	3–5 yrs
77	Story basket	3–5 yrs	92	Recycling sort	3–5 yrs
78	Sandwich chef	3–5 yrs	93	Pouring station	3–5 yrs
79	Chalk hopscotch	3–5 yrs	94	You design the course	3–5 yrs
80	Red light, green light	3–5 yrs	95	Best part of today	3–5 yrs
81	Café with a menu	3–5 yrs	96	Picture shopping list	3–5 yrs
82	Family mail carrier	3–5 yrs	97	Dress-up job day	3–5 yrs
83	Shadow tracing	3–5 yrs	98	Sticky-note hunt	3–5 yrs
84	Rhyme silly names	3–5 yrs	99	Tightrope walk	3–5 yrs
85	Build a zoo	3–5 yrs	100	Plan tomorrow's play	3–5 yrs

Every child grows at their own pace, and ages here are a guide, not a deadline. If you have questions about how your child is growing, moving or talking, ask your child's doctor.



71

PLAY 71 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Box rocket

🕒 10-min prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: a big cardboard box, crayons, tape

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

The grown-up cuts a door and a round window. Your child decorates the rocket, chooses where it will fly and leads the countdown. Where do you land?

Make it easier: Skip the cutting: sit in the open box and do the countdown.

Make it harder: Make a mission control desk and plan a trip to the moon.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“Where are we flying today?”

✅ **Safety:** The grown-up does all the cutting. Take off staples first.



72

PLAY 72 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Blanket fort

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Indoors · Wind-down

🛒 You need: a blanket, 2-3 chairs, pillows

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Drape a blanket over chairs to make a fort. Fill it with pillows, books and a flashlight. Make up a password to get in.

Make it easier: Drape the blanket over one chair, or over the table.

Make it harder: Add a "night in the fort": read stories inside with a flashlight.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“Who lives in our fort? What’s the password?”

✅ **Safety:** Nothing heavy on top. Keep the fort away from lamps, heaters and cords.

73



PLAY 73 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

I spy colors

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Waiting & car
 📦 You need: *Nothing but you*

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Choose something you can both see and say its color. Your child guesses. Then swap. Add a second clue if needed: "It's blue and it's round."

Make it easier: Spy things close by, like your own shirt or the seat.

Make it harder: Switch to shapes: "I spy something shaped like a circle."

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"I spy something... blue!"

✅ **Safety:** A perfect waiting game. In the car, your child stays buckled in.

74



PLAY 74 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Scavenger hunt

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Outdoors
 📦 You need: a picture list you draw, a paper or cloth bag

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Draw 5 simple things to find: a leaf, a stick, a flower, something round, something rough. Hunt together and check them off.

Make it easier: Look for three things, all the same color.

Make it harder: Add harder things to find: something that smells nice, something tiny.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



"What did you find? Tell me about it."

✅ **Safety:** Stay where you can see each other. No berries or mushrooms, nothing in mouths. Wash hands after.



75

PLAY 75 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Play-dough bakery

🕒 No prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Indoors · Kitchen

🛒 **You need:** store-bought play dough, a rolling pin, cookie cutters

Open a pretend bakery. Your child rolls, cuts and "bakes" dough cookies and cakes. You are the customer: order something silly and ask the price.

Make it easier: Just roll balls and "sell" them one at a time.

Make it harder: Add a price list and pay with pretend coins.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



"What are you baking? How much is it?"

✅ **Safety:** Use dough labeled for your child's age. It's not for eating; keep it away from babies.



76

PLAY 76 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Simon says

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Outdoors · Big energy

🛒 **You need:** *Nothing but you*

🏠 **NOTHING TO BUY**

Give simple actions: touch your nose, jump, spin. Only follow when you hear "Simon says". Let your child be Simon next.

Make it easier: Play without the trick: copy every move.

Make it harder: Add "Simon says" to other games, like tidying up.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture



"Simon says... touch your toes!"

✅ **Safety:** Clear space to move. Spins are slow and short.

77



PLAY 77 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Story basket

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Wind-down

🛒 You need: 3 random household objects

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Pull three objects from a basket, such as a spoon, a hat and a shoe. Start a story that uses all three, then pass it to your child to continue.

Make it easier: Use one object and tell a two-line story together.

Make it harder: Draw the story in three boxes: beginning, middle and end.

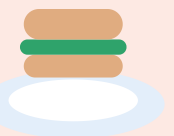
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“Once upon a time, a spoon found a hat... and then?”

✅ **Safety:** If a baby or toddler is near, choose objects too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

78



PLAY 78 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Sandwich chef

🕒 2-min prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Kitchen

🛒 You need: bread, a spread, a butter knife

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Your child makes their own sandwich: spread, top and fold. Talk through the steps in order: first, next, last. Cut shapes with a cookie cutter for fun.

Make it easier: Put the bread on the plate first; your child just spreads and folds.

Make it harder: Let your child plan a picnic lunch and pack it.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“What goes first: bread or spread?”

✅ **Safety:** Blunt butter knife only. Check for food allergies and spread thinly. The grown-up handles sharp knives, the stove and the oven.

79



PLAY 79 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Chalk hopscotch

🕒 2-min prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Outdoors · Big energy
 🛒 You need: sidewalk chalk

Draw a simple hopscotch with numbers. Hop on one foot, land on two. Say each number as you hop. Try it backwards!

Make it easier: Draw three squares in a line and jump with two feet.

Make it harder: Add a throw: toss a beanbag or sock onto a square, then hop to it.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



“Hop on one... land on two!”

✅ **Safety:** Play on a quiet path or driveway, away from traffic.

80



PLAY 80 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Red light, green light

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Outdoors · Big energy
 🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

You are the traffic light. "Green light" means walk or run toward you; "red light" means stop. Add "yellow light" for slow motion.

Make it easier: Just walk and stop together, holding hands.

Make it harder: Add new colors: "blue light" means walk backwards.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



“Green light... RED light!”

✅ **Safety:** Play in a fenced yard or park, well away from the road.

81



PLAY 81 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Café with a menu

⌚ 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Indoors · Kitchen

📦 You need: paper and crayons, toy food or snacks

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Draw a menu together with pictures and prices. Your child takes orders on a notepad and serves. Pay with pretend money and leave a tip.

Make it easier: Skip the menu and take orders out loud.

Make it harder: Add a specials board and let your child invent a new dish.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“What would you like to order today?”

✅ **Safety:** If real snacks are served, check for food allergies, and no whole grapes, nuts or popcorn near younger siblings.

82



PLAY 82 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Family mail carrier

⌚ 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

📦 You need: paper, envelopes, crayons

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Your child draws "letters" and delivers them to family members or teddies around the house. Read each letter aloud together.

Make it easier: Deliver one letter to one person in the same room.

Make it harder: Set up a "post office" with a box and a pretend stamp.

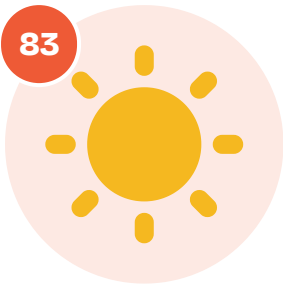
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“Who is this letter for? What does it say?”

✅ **Safety:** No running on stairs with arms full. Walk the letters around.

83



PLAY 83 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Shadow tracing

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Outdoors

🛒 You need: paper, crayons, a few toys

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

On a sunny day, stand a toy on paper and trace its shadow. Come back an hour later: where did the shadow move? Trace it again in another color.

Make it easier: Stand in the sun and watch your shadows move as you wave.

Make it harder: Trace at breakfast, lunch and dinner and compare the three shadows.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



“The shadow moved! Now it’s long and thin.”

✅ **Safety:** Hats and sunscreen, and never look straight at the sun.

84



PLAY 84 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Rhyme silly names

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Waiting & car

🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Say a word and find rhymes together, real or silly: cat, hat, bat, zat! Then rhyme each other’s names. Laughing is the point.

Make it easier: Stick to one easy word, like "cat", and take turns with rhymes, real or silly.

Make it harder: Try first sounds: "ball, bear, banana... what else starts like that?"

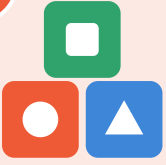
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



“Cat, hat, bat... what rhymes with dog?”

✅ **Safety:** A great waiting-room or car game: no materials, nothing to drop.

85



PLAY 85 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Build a zoo

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Indoors
🛒 You need: blocks, toy animals

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Build pens from blocks for each animal. Your child is the zookeeper: who lives where, what do they eat, who is awake? Take a "tour".

Make it easier: Build one pen for one animal.

Make it harder: Make a map of the zoo with paths and a gift shop.

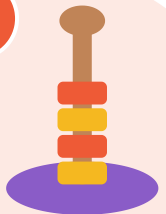
TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



"Who lives here? What does the lion eat?"

✅ **Safety:** Small toy animals are fine for 3+ but must stay away from babies and toddlers.

86



PLAY 86 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Pasta tower

🕒 2-min prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Kitchen
🛒 You need: a lump of play dough, a wooden spoon, dry penne pasta

Stand the spoon upright in the dough. Your child threads pasta onto the handle to build a tower, counting as they go. Make patterns: big, little, big.

Make it easier: Hold the spoon steady for your child and skip the patterns.

Make it harder: Make a pattern of three: big, little, little, big, little, little.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



"How many now? Let's count!"

✅ **Safety:** Dry pasta is a choking risk for under-3s: keep it away from little siblings. Towers, not necklaces.

87



PLAY 87 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Feelings faces

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: paper plates, chunky crayons

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Draw a different face on each plate: happy, sad, cross, surprised. Hold one up and make up a reason: "Bear is sad because..."

Make it easier: Use two faces only: happy and sad.

Make it harder: Act out a feeling and let your child guess which face matches.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



"How does Bear feel? Why, do you think?"

✅ **Safety:** Keep marker caps and small crayon bits away from younger siblings.

88



PLAY 88 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Measure with feet

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Outdoors

🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Guess how many of your child's feet long the sofa is. Walk heel to toe and count. Then measure with a grown-up foot and compare.

Make it easier: Measure something short, like a rug or a step.

Make it harder: Measure with spoons, blocks or hands and compare.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"Guess first! How many feet?"

✅ **Safety:** Walk slowly on a clear floor.

89



PLAY 89 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Little gardeners

🕒 No prep 💧💧 Messy ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Outdoors

🛒 You need: a trowel or spoon, gloves

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Dig a patch of soil together. Look for worms, roots and bugs. Plant a seed and give it a name. Check it every day.

Make it easier: Dig one small patch together and just look for worms.

Make it harder: Keep a "plant diary" with a drawing each week.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"Dig, dig... a worm! A wiggly worm."

✅ **Safety:** Check the soil for glass or sharp bits first. No berries or mushrooms. Wash hands after.

90



PLAY 90 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Paper plane contest

🕒 2-min prep 💧💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Outdoors

🛒 You need: paper

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Fold simple planes together. Throw them and mark where they land with a sock or a crayon. Change the folds and see which flies farther.

Make it easier: Crumple the paper into a ball and throw that instead.

Make it harder: Add a target: a laundry basket to land in.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"Which one went farther? Why?"

✅ **Safety:** Throw away from faces, in an open room or outside.

91



PLAY 91 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Puppet show

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: socks for puppets, a sofa as the stage

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Kneel behind the sofa and make sock puppets talk. Your child plans the show: who is in it, and what goes wrong? Take turns being the audience.

Make it easier: Make one sock puppet say hello from behind the sofa.

Make it harder: Make tickets and invite the family to the show.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“What does your puppet want to say?”

✅ **Safety:** No buttons or stick-on eyes on puppets if younger siblings will play too.

92



PLAY 92 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Recycling sort

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Kitchen

🛒 You need: clean paper, plastic and cans, 3 boxes

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Label three boxes with pictures: paper, plastic, cans. Your child sorts clean recycling into them and explains why each thing goes where it goes.

Make it easier: Sort into two boxes: paper and not paper.

Make it harder: Count each pile and find out which one is biggest.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“Where does this go? How do you know?”

✅ **Safety:** Rinse items first. Cans with sharp rims and lids stay with the grown-up. No glass.

93



PLAY 93 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Pouring station

🕒 2-min prep 💧 💧 Messy ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Outdoors · Bath time

🛒 You need: jugs, a funnel, cups, a tub of water

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Set up jugs, cups and a funnel over a tub of water. Pour from big to small, fill to the top, fill halfway. Guess how many cups fill the jug.

Make it easier: Use one cup and one jug.

Make it harder: Add food coloring to two jugs and mix a new color.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“Full, half full or empty?”

✅ **Safety:** Stay right there. Even a little water is a risk for small children. Tip it out after.

94



PLAY 94 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

You design the course

🕒 2-min prep 💧 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Big energy

🛒 You need: cushions, tape, a chair

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Your child designs an obstacle course for you to try. They give the instructions; you follow them exactly (and slowly, for laughs).

Make it easier: Your child gives one instruction at a time.

Make it harder: Add a timer song and see if the course can be done before it ends.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“You’re the boss! What do I do first?”

✅ **Safety:** Everything at floor level. No standing on furniture.



95

PLAY 95 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Best part of today

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 5 min 📍 Wind-down
 🛒 You need: *Nothing but you*

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

At bedtime, take turns: the best part of today, a funny part, and one thing to look forward to tomorrow. Share yours first.

Make it easier: Share just one thing: the best part.

Make it harder: Add "something kind someone did today".

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait



"What was the best part of today? Mine was..."

✓ **Safety:** Keep blind and lamp cords well out of reach of the bed.



96

PLAY 96 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Picture shopping list

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Waiting & car
 🛒 You need: paper, crayons

[🏠 NOTHING TO BUY](#)

Before shopping, draw a picture list together. In the shop, your child finds each item and ticks it off.

Make it easier: Put three things on the list.

Make it harder: Let your child hold the list and read the pictures to you.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



"Bananas! You found the bananas. Tick!"

✓ **Safety:** In the parking lot, hold hands or keep a hand on the cart.

97



PLAY 97 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Dress-up job day

🕒 No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays 20+ min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: hats, handbags or tote bags, old clothes

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Your child chooses a job: builder, chef, farmer, pilot. Find clothes and tools around the house and spend ten minutes on the job together.

Make it easier: Add one hat and choose a job.

Make it harder: Mix two jobs: a chef who is also an astronaut.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead



“What’s your job today? What do you need?”

✅ **Safety:** No cords or strings around necks, no plastic bags, and no long capes that trip.

98



PLAY 98 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Sticky-note hunt

🕒 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors

🛒 You need: sticky notes, a crayon

🏠 NOTHING TO BUY

Draw a shape or a color dot on each note and stick them around one room. Your child hunts for them and names each one.

Make it easier: Stick the notes where your child can see them from the doorway.

Make it harder: Hide letters from your child’s name and spell it when all are found.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see



“You found a circle! Where’s the next one?”

✅ **Safety:** Collect every note after, so younger siblings can’t chew them.



99

PLAY 99 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Tightrope walk

⌚ 2-min prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min

📍 Indoors · Outdoors · Big energy

🛠 You need: painter's tape

Make a straight line on the floor. Walk it forwards, backwards, on tiptoe, with arms out wide. Add a zig-zag for a challenge.

Make it easier: Walk the line forwards, holding hands.

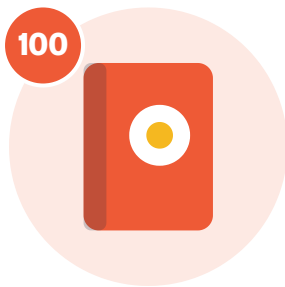
Make it harder: Carry a beanbag or a sock on your head while you walk.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one



“Arms out wide... can you walk backwards?”

✓ **Safety:** The line stays flat on the floor. No raised boards or beams.



100

PLAY 100 From 36 mo Best for 3-5 yrs

Plan tomorrow's play

⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ Plays about 10 min 📍 Indoors · Wind-down

🛠 You need: paper, crayons, this book

🏠 **NOTHING TO BUY**

Flip through this book together and choose three plays for tomorrow. Your child draws a little picture of each one. Stick the plan on the fridge.

Make it easier: Choose one play for tomorrow together.

Make it harder: Let your child choose one play for the whole family on the weekend.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice



“What should we play first tomorrow?”

✓ **Safety:** Choose plays from your child's age band and check each safety note.



OUR OWN PLAY

age: _____

☐ No prep ☐ 2 min ☐ 10 min ☐ None ☐ A little ☐ Messy ☐ 5 ☐ 10 ☐ 20+

You need: _____

HOW TO PLAY

Easier: _____ Harder: _____

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY



Safety: _____



OUR OWN PLAY

age: _____

☐ No prep ☐ 2 min ☐ 10 min ☐ None ☐ A little ☐ Messy ☐ 5 ☐ 10 ☐ 20+

You need: _____

HOW TO PLAY

Easier: _____ Harder: _____

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY



Safety: _____

Tired-grown-up plays

Some days you have nothing left, and that's normal. These plays count just as much. Sit or lie down, do one, and call it a win.

From 4 mo 2 MIN • NO SETUP

Couch peekaboo

You need: a cushion

Stay sitting. Hide your face behind a cushion, wait, then pop out with a smile.

 **"Where did I go? ... Here I am!"**

 **Safety:** Hide your own face. Never cover your baby's face.

From birth 2 MIN • NO SETUP

Chest chat

You need: nothing

Lie back on the sofa or floor with your baby on your chest, facing you. Talk, hum and copy each coo.

 **"Ooh? ... Ooh! You're talking to me."**

 **Safety:** Stay awake. If you feel sleepy, lay your baby on their back in the crib.

From birth 2 MIN • NO SETUP

This little piggy

You need: nothing

Count your child's toes with the old rhyme. Slow down before the last line and wait for the giggle.

 **"...and this little piggy went... (wait) wee, wee, wee!"**

 **Safety:** Gentle touches. Stop if your child pulls away.

From 6 mo 2 MIN • NO SETUP

Pat-a-cake

You need: nothing

Clap hands together to "Pat-a-cake". Help little hands at first, then pause and see if your child claps on their own.

 **"Pat it and roll it... (wait) ...and mark it with a B!"**

 **Safety:** Soft claps. Support a young baby who is sitting.

From 12 mo 2 MIN • NO SETUP

Which hand?

You need: a sock or a toy

Hide the sock behind your back, then hold out two fists. Your child picks a hand. Swap roles.

 **"This hand or that hand?"**

 **Safety:** For under-3s, the toy must be too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

From 12 mo 2 MIN • NO SETUP

I'm a mountain

You need: nothing

Lie on your back on a rug. Your toddler climbs over you like a mountain, again and again, while you stay put.

 **"Up the mountain... and down the other side!"**

 **Safety:** You stay lying down on a soft floor, away from furniture corners.

From 12 mo 2 MIN • NO SETUP

Sing what's happening

You need: nothing

Sing about right now to any tune you know: "We are sitting on the couch, on the couch."



"Now we're yawning on the couch, on the couch!"

✓ **Safety:** Sing where you can see your child, and keep the couch clear of cords.

From 18 mo 2 MIN • NO SETUP

Sock toss

You need: rolled-up socks, a laundry basket

Roll socks into balls. Stay on the couch and cheer while your child throws them into the basket and fetches them back.



"In! ... Oh, missed! Try again?"

✓ **Safety:** Soft rolled socks only, too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

From 18 mo 2 MIN • NO SETUP

Blanket boat

You need: a blanket

Sit on a blanket on the floor: it's a boat. Row with pretend oars and spot pretend fish over the side.



"Row, row... I see a fish! What do you see?"

✓ **Safety:** Sit on the floor. No blankets over heads.

From 24 mo 2 MIN • NO SETUP

Guess the sound

You need: nothing

Your child closes their eyes. Make one sound (a clap, a knock, a hum, a click of the tongue) and let them guess. Swap.



"Listen... what was that?"

✓ **Safety:** Quiet sounds only, close by.

From 30 mo 2 MIN • NO SETUP

Robot grown-up

You need: nothing

You are a robot on the couch. Your child gives the orders ("wave!", "blink!", "beep!") and you do them, very slowly.



"Beep boop. What... is... my... next... job?"

✓ **Safety:** Robot moves stay seated. No climbing on the couch arms.

From 36 mo 2 MIN • NO SETUP

Ceiling story

You need: nothing

Lie side by side and look up. Pick a spot on the ceiling and make up a story about it, one sentence each.



"That crack is a river. Who lives by the river?"

✓ **Safety:** Lie on a clear floor or bed, away from blind and lamp cords.

Also good from the couch: Face to face **1** Point-and-talk book **19** Which cup? **27** Photo stories **66**

Rhyme silly names **84** Best part of today **95** . And every play in the book has a **Make it easier** line when energy is low.

A sample screen-free day

This is a sample, not a schedule. Real days wobble. Pick one or two ideas and keep what works. If a show is part of your day, give it one fixed spot (page 81).

7:00	Wake up and get dressed Sing along as you go.	This is the way... 40
7:30	Breakfast Offer two choices and wait.	Snack choice 37
8:15	Tidy the kitchen together Your child plays at your feet.	Pots and lids 43 Kitchen band 11
9:00	Outside A walk, the park or the garden.	Nature bag walk 41 Bubble chase 26
10:15	Snack and a book Point, name and let them turn pages.	Point-and-talk book 19
10:45	Big energy Before lunch, when wiggles peak.	Pillow mountain 30 Freeze dance 52
11:30	Lunch, then nap or quiet rest Rest counts. So does a cup of tea for you.	
2:30	Pretend play Join in with a small role.	Soup kitchen 48 Tea party 65
3:30	Out and about Errands become games.	Finish the rhyme 70 Animal sounds 28
4:30	Free play nearby Your child plays alone while you cook. That counts.	
5:30	Dinner and bath Always within arm's reach in the bath.	Pour and splash 8 Float or sink? 60
6:45	Wind-down Same order, same songs, every night.	Teddy's bedtime 59 Row, row, stop! 16

Three short plays is a great day. The rest is ordinary life with you nearby, and that is plenty.

Swap it for your age and your energy

A baby day (0–1)

Morning cuddle: Face to face **1**

Tell the diaper change **3**

Floor time: Tummy-time mirror chat **2**

Rolling ball chase **9**

Kitchen time: Kitchen band **11**

Kitchen dance party **20**

Bath and bed: Pour and splash **8**

Row, row, stop! **16**

A preschool day (3–5)

Morning: Plan tomorrow's play **100**

Simon says **76**

Outside: Scavenger hunt **74**

Red light, green light **80**

Afternoon project: Box rocket **71**

Blanket fort **72**

Bedtime: Best part of today **95**

Story basket **77**

Low-energy grown-up? These plays let you sit or lie down.

Face to face **1** Point-and-talk book **19** Which cup? **27** Tea party **65** Photo stories **66**

Play-dough bakery **75** Rhyme silly names **84** Best part of today **95**

Tricky moments, ready plays

Waiting for dinner Pots and lids **43** Soup kitchen **48** Salad helper **58**

In a waiting room I spy colors **73** Rhyme silly names **84** Mystery bag **54**

Baby asleep, big sibling awake Story basket **77** Puppet show **91** Feelings faces **87**

Rainy afternoon Living-room obstacle course **50** Blanket fort **72** Box rocket **71**

When screens are on anyway

Screens are part of family life. This book isn't about being perfect. It's about adding more play and talk around the screen time you already have.

- 1 **Watch together when you can.**
Sit with your child, talk about what you see, sing the songs and link it to real life: "A red bus! Like the one we saw."
- 2 **Choose slow and simple.**
Calmer shows with one story at a time are easier to talk about than fast, busy ones.
- 3 **Background TV off.**
When nobody is really watching, switch it off. It's hard to talk and play over it.
- 4 **Warn, then land.**
"Two more minutes, then Pillow Mountain!" Have the next play ready so the switch feels like a treat.
- 5 **Give screens a spot in the day.**
A regular time, say while dinner cooks, that doesn't grow or shrink with chores or behavior. Meals and the hour before bed make easy screen-free spots.
- 6 **Video calls are different.**
A call with Grandma is a real back-and-forth conversation. Help your child wave, show and tell.
- 7 **Give phones a spot too.**
A basket by the door during play time makes it easier for everyone to join in.
- 8 **Tomorrow is a new day.**
A show while you shower or cook is ordinary life. Pick one play tomorrow and carry on.

WHAT THE GUIDELINES SAY

World Health Organization (2019): sedentary screen time is not recommended for babies under 1 or 1-year-olds; for 2- to 4-year-olds, no more than 1 hour a day, and less is better.

American Academy of Pediatrics (2016): for children younger than 18 months, avoid screen media other than video-chatting; for ages 2 to 5, limit screen use to 1 hour a day of high-quality programming, ideally watched together.



Even the tablet likes a rest. Sometimes.

The 100-play tracker

Color in a circle each time you try a play. Star your favorites to come back to.

☐ 1 Face to face	☐ 26 Bubble chase	☐ 51 Tape road	☐ 76 Simon says
☐ 2 Tummy-time mirror chat	☐ 27 Which cup?	☐ 52 Freeze dance	☐ 77 Story basket
☐ 3 Tell the diaper change	☐ 28 Animal sounds	☐ 53 Shadow shapes	☐ 78 Sandwich chef
☐ 4 Hello, Sock!	☐ 29 Box car	☐ 54 Mystery bag	☐ 79 Chalk hopscotch
☐ 5 Kick to the beat	☐ 30 Pillow mountain	☐ 55 Corner shop	☐ 80 Red light, green light
☐ 6 Where's the sound?	☐ 31 Wash the baby doll	☐ 56 Puddle jumping	☐ 81 Café with a menu
☐ 7 Peekaboo towel	☐ 32 Scoop and pour	☐ 57 Chalk outlines	☐ 82 Family mail carrier
☐ 8 Pour and splash	☐ 33 Ramp race	☐ 58 Salad helper	☐ 83 Shadow tracing
☐ 9 Rolling ball chase	☐ 34 Laundry helper	☐ 59 Teddy's bedtime	☐ 84 Rhyme silly names
☐ 10 Pull-out box	☐ 35 Tape peel	☐ 60 Float or sink?	☐ 85 Build a zoo
☐ 11 Kitchen band	☐ 36 Flying high	☐ 61 Stomp and tiptoe	☐ 86 Pasta tower
☐ 12 In and out bucket	☐ 37 Snack choice	☐ 62 Shoe match	☐ 87 Feelings faces
☐ 13 Build and crash	☐ 38 Mirror faces	☐ 63 Count the tower	☐ 88 Measure with feet
☐ 14 Bye-bye, hello!	☐ 39 Push it along	☐ 64 Hot and cold hunt	☐ 89 Little gardeners
☐ 15 Leaf look	☐ 40 This is the way...	☐ 65 Tea party	☐ 90 Paper plane contest
☐ 16 Row, row, stop!	☐ 41 Nature bag walk	☐ 66 Photo stories	☐ 91 Puppet show
☐ 17 Cushion tunnel	☐ 42 Knock, knock!	☐ 67 Plate-wheel drive	☐ 92 Recycling sort
☐ 18 Name-it walk	☐ 43 Pots and lids	☐ 68 Giant floor mural	☐ 93 Pouring station
☐ 19 Point-and-talk book	☐ 44 Follow me, follow you	☐ 69 Counting stairs	☐ 94 You design the course
☐ 20 Kitchen dance party	☐ 45 Pretend phone call	☐ 70 Finish the rhyme	☐ 95 Best part of today
☐ 21 Posting box	☐ 46 Big-box house	☐ 71 Box rocket	☐ 96 Picture shopping list
☐ 22 Laundry basket ride	☐ 47 Color sort	☐ 72 Blanket fort	☐ 97 Dress-up job day
☐ 23 Sticky wall	☐ 48 Soup kitchen	☐ 73 I spy colors	☐ 98 Sticky-note hunt
☐ 24 Big sock, little sock	☐ 49 Toy wash	☐ 74 Scavenger hunt	☐ 99 Tightrope walk
☐ 25 Water painting	☐ 50 Living-room obstacle course	☐ 75 Play-dough bakery	☐ 100 Plan tomorrow's play

Our play week

Week of _____ Our star play _____

DAY	PLAY #	PLAY AND TALK LINE	BEST MOMENT
Monday	_____	_____	_____
Tuesday	_____	_____	_____
Wednesday	_____	_____	_____
Thursday	_____	_____	_____
Friday	_____	_____	_____
Saturday	_____	_____	_____
Sunday	_____	_____	_____

Tip: plan three plays a day at most. Leave room for boredom, naps and the unexpected. More planners, with Monday and Sunday starts, are at the back of this file.

Sources

World Health Organization. *Guidelines on physical activity, sedentary behaviour and sleep for children under 5 years of age*. Geneva: WHO; 2019.

American Academy of Pediatrics, Council on Communications and Media. Media and Young Minds. *Pediatrics*. 2016;138(5):e20162591.

Brushe ME, et al. Screen time and parent-child talk when children are aged 12 to 36 months. *JAMA Pediatrics*. 2024;178(4):369–375.

These sources describe links (associations) found in research and public-health guidance. They are not claims about any single child, and nothing in this book is a treatment or a promise of any result.

How these plays were chosen

Every play uses everyday things, takes ten minutes or less to set up, and follows the rules on the "Safety first" page: a grown-up right there, the toilet-paper tube test for under-3s, no balloons, no long cords or strings, water always supervised and no choking-risk foods. Each one comes with something to say, because the talk is the point.



About Play Before Pixels

Play Before Pixels makes calm, practical play-and-talk resources for families with young children: books, printables and card sets built around one simple idea. The first years are built on talk, touch and play, so let's make room for plenty of back-and-forth.

Play ideas are general parent education. They are not professional or clinical advice.



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THANK YOU

What's next

Thank you for playing along. When your child is ready for something new, these are made to go with this book.



I'm Bored Play Cards

150 age-banded play cards with a talk prompt on every card



Visual Routine Cards

200+ picture cards for mornings, meals and bedtime



Up! Go! More!

A talk-along first-words book for ages 0–3

Where to find them

Look for the Play Before Pixels shop on Etsy. Your files stay in your Etsy account under Purchases, so you can download them again at any time.

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Monday	_____	_____	_____
Tuesday	_____	_____	_____
Wednesday	_____	_____	_____
Thursday	_____	_____	_____
Friday	_____	_____	_____
Saturday	_____	_____	_____
Sunday	_____	_____	_____

Tip: plan three plays a day at most. Leave room for boredom, naps and the unexpected. Type into the lines in free Adobe Acrobat Reader, or print and write.

Our play week

Week of _____ Our star play _____

DAY	PLAY #	PLAY AND TALK LINE	BEST MOMENT
Sunday	_____	_____	_____
Monday	_____	_____	_____
Tuesday	_____	_____	_____
Wednesday	_____	_____	_____
Thursday	_____	_____	_____
Friday	_____	_____	_____
Saturday	_____	_____	_____

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Our play week

Week of _____ Our star play _____

DAY	PLAY #	PLAY AND TALK LINE	BEST MOMENT
Sunday	_____	_____	_____
Monday	_____	_____	_____
Tuesday	_____	_____	_____
Wednesday	_____	_____	_____
Thursday	_____	_____	_____
Friday	_____	_____	_____
Saturday	_____	_____	_____

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Our play week

Week of _____ Our star play _____

DAY	PLAY #	PLAY AND TALK LINE	BEST MOMENT
Monday	_____	_____	_____
Tuesday	_____	_____	_____
Wednesday	_____	_____	_____
Thursday	_____	_____	_____
Friday	_____	_____	_____
Saturday	_____	_____	_____
Sunday	_____	_____	_____

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Favorites and funny moments